

Reading Texts in Indian English –I

Syllabus and Question Paper Pattern

Poetry

1. Goodbye Party for Miss Pushpa T.S. – Nissim Ezekiel
2. Pilgrimage – Shiv K. Kumar
3. The Ghaghra in Spate – Keki N. Daruwalla
4. On Killing a Tree – Gieve Patel

Short Stories

1. The Doctor's Word – R. K. Narayan
2. The Lost Child – Mulk Raj Anand
3. The Old Banyan Tree – Ruskin Bond

Question Paper Pattern

Total Marks: 30

Q.1. Choose the correct alternatives from the following.

(Unit 1 & 2)

Marks: 6

Q.2. Answer any two out of four of the following.

(Unit 1 & 2)

Marks: 6

Q.3. Write short notes on any one of the two questions.

(Unit 1)

Marks: 6

Q.4. A broad question with alternatives (A/B).

(Unit 2)

Marks: 12

Poetry

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1. Goodbye Party for Miss Pushpa T.S. – Nissim Ezekiel

About the Poet: Nissim Ezekiel

Nissim Ezekiel (1924–2004) was a pioneering Indian English poet, playwright, and critic. Known as the father of modern Indian English poetry, he used simple language, wit, and humor to depict the life and culture of urban India. His poems often explore themes of identity, social issues, and the quirks of Indian English. Ezekiel's work made a significant contribution to establishing Indian English poetry as a serious literary genre.

About the Poem: Goodbye Party for Miss Pushpa T.S.

“Goodbye Party for Miss Pushpa T.S.”* is a humorous and satirical poem by Nissim Ezekiel that depicts a farewell party for an office colleague, Miss Pushpa. The poem mocks the awkward and often incorrect use of English by Indians during such social occasions. Through comic exaggeration, it highlights the artificiality of formal farewell speeches and the cultural blend of Indian and English traditions. The poem reflects the middle-class Indian office culture and the challenges of using English as a second language.

Theme of the Poem

The poem satirizes the farewell party given to Miss Pushpa, exposing the awkwardness and humor in the Indian middle-class practice of using English in social and official settings. It highlights the artificiality of such ceremonies and mocks the clumsy, often incorrect, use of English phrases. The poem also touches

on themes of friendship, social formalities, and the cultural clash between Indian tradition and colonial English influence.

Important Points

Satire and Humor: The poem humorously critiques the over-the-top and often meaningless farewell speeches in Indian offices.

Use of Indian English: The poem captures the typical Indian English spoken by middle-class Indians, full of grammatical errors and literal translations.

Cultural Hybrid: It shows the blend of Indian cultural practices with English language traditions in postcolonial India.

Social Formality: The poem mocks how people exaggerate emotions and politeness during farewells.

Character of Miss Pushpa: She is portrayed as a well-liked colleague whose departure creates a gap, but the poem focuses more on the absurdity of the speeches than on her as a person.

Tone: Light-hearted, ironic, and sarcastic.

Friends,
our dear sister
is departing for foreign
in two three days,
and
we are meeting today
to wish her bon voyage.

You are all knowing, friends,
What sweetness is in Miss Pushpa.
I don't mean only external sweetness
but internal sweetness.
Miss Pushpa is smiling and smiling
even for no reason but simply because
she is feeling.

Miss Pushpa is coming

from very high family.
Her father was renowned advocate
in Bulsar or Surat,
I am not remembering now which place.

Surat? Ah, yes,
once only I stayed in Surat
with family members
of my uncle's very old friend-
his wife was cooking nicely...
that was long time ago.

Coming back to Miss Pushpa
she is most popular lady
with men also and ladies also.

Whenever I asked her to do anything,
she was saying, 'Just now only
I will do it.' That is showing
good spirit. I am always
appreciating the good spirit.

Pushpa Miss is never saying no.
Whatever I or anybody is asking
she is always saying yes,
and today she is going
to improve her prospect
and we are wishing her bon voyage.
Now I ask other speakers to speak
and afterwards Miss Pushpa
will do summing up.

Choose the Correct Alternatives (MCQs)

1. **Who is the poet of “Goodbye Party for Miss Pushpa T.S.”?**

- a) Kamala Das
- b) Nissim Ezekiel
- c) R.K. Narayan
- d) A.K. Ramanujan

Answer: b) Nissim Ezekiel

2. **Why have the people gathered together?**

- a) To celebrate Miss Pushpa’s birthday
- b) To welcome Miss Pushpa
- c) To wish Miss Pushpa bon voyage
- d) To celebrate her marriage

Answer: c) To wish Miss Pushpa bon voyage

3. **Where is Miss Pushpa going?**

- a) America
- b) England
- c) Abroad
- d) Australia

Answer: c) Abroad

4. **What does the speaker praise in Miss Pushpa?**

- a) Her intelligence
- b) Her sweetness
- c) Her wealth
- d) Her beauty alone

Answer: b) Her sweetness

5. **According to the speaker, Miss Pushpa has sweetness that is:**

- a) Only external
- b) Only internal
- c) Both external and internal
- d) Neither external nor internal

Answer: c) Both external and internal

6. **Miss Pushpa’s father was a renowned:**

- a) Doctor
- b) Teacher
- c) Advocate
- d) Businessman

Answer: c) Advocate

7. **The speaker is confused about whether Miss Pushpa’s father was an advocate in:**

- a) Mumbai or Pune
- b) Bulsar or Surat
- c) Delhi or Agra
- d) Ahmedabad or Baroda

Answer: b) Bulsar or Surat

8. What does the speaker suddenly remember about Surat?

- a) A court case
- b) A business trip
- c) Staying with family members of his uncle's old friend
- d) A school function

Answer: c) Staying with family members of his uncle's old friend

9. What does the speaker remember about the old friend's wife?

- a) She sang well
- b) She cooked nicely
- c) She taught him English
- d) She was a doctor

Answer: b) She cooked nicely

10. Miss Pushpa is popular with:

- a) Men only
- b) Ladies only
- c) Men and ladies both
- d) Children only

Answer: c) Men and ladies both

11. What does Miss Pushpa usually say when asked to do something?

- a) "I cannot do it."
- b) "Never."
- c) "Just now only I will do it."
- d) "I will do it tomorrow."

Answer: c) "Just now only I will do it."

12. The speaker considers Miss Pushpa's response a sign of her:

- a) Anger
- b) Good spirit
- c) Laziness
- d) Intelligence

Answer: b) Good spirit

13. Miss Pushpa is described as someone who:

- a) Always says no
- b) Never says no
- c) Rarely speaks

d) Always argues

Answer: b) Never says no

14. Why is Miss Pushpa going abroad?

a) To visit relatives

b) To improve her prospects

c) To attend a wedding

d) To study history

Answer: b) To improve her prospects

15. What does the speaker wish Miss Pushpa?

a) Good luck in examinations

b) Happy birthday

c) Bon voyage

d) Happy marriage

Answer: c) Bon voyage

16. Who is asked to speak after the speaker?

a) Miss Pushpa's father

b) Other speakers

c) Miss Pushpa's mother

d) The host

Answer: b) Other speakers

17. What will Miss Pushpa do after the other speakers?

a) Sing a song

b) Give a speech and leave

c) Do the "summing up"

d) Distribute sweets

Answer: c) Do the "summing up"

18. The poem is mainly written in the form of a:

a) Love letter

b) Farewell speech

c) Newspaper article

d) Personal diary

Answer: b) Farewell speech

19. The major source of humour in the poem is the speaker's:

a) Silence

b) Formal vocabulary

c) Digressions and unconventional Indian English

d) Knowledge of foreign languages

Answer: c) Digressions and unconventional Indian English

20. "Goodbye Party for Miss Pushpa T.S." is best described as a:

a) Tragedy

- b) Satirical and humorous poem
- c) Romantic poem
- d) Nature poem

Answer: b) Satirical and humorous poem

Short Questions

1. What is the theme of the poem "Goodbye Party for Miss Pushpa T.S."?
2. Describe the tone of the poem.
3. How is the English language used in the poem?
4. Where is Miss Pushpa going to depart?
5. What kind of sweetness does Miss Pushpa have according to the speaker?
6. What was the profession of Miss Pushpa's father?
7. Which city did the speaker once stay in?
8. How does Miss Pushpa respond when asked to do something?
9. What quality of Miss Pushpa does the speaker appreciate?
10. Why are the friends meeting today?
11. What will Miss Pushpa do at the end of the meeting?
12. How does the speaker describe Miss Pushpa's popularity?
13. What does Miss Pushpa hope to improve by going abroad?

One or Two Sentence Questions

1. Why have the friends gathered together?
2. How does the speaker describe Miss Pushpa's sweetness?
3. What does the speaker say about Miss Pushpa's family background?
4. Why does the speaker mention Surat in the poem?
5. How does the speaker describe Miss Pushpa's popularity?
6. What does Miss Pushpa usually say when she is asked to do something?
7. Why does the speaker appreciate Miss Pushpa's "good spirit"?
8. What does the speaker mean by saying that Miss Pushpa "is never saying no"?
9. Why is Miss Pushpa going abroad?
10. What is humorous about the speaker's farewell speech?
11. What is the significance of the title *Goodbye Party for Miss Pushpa T.S.*?
12. How does the poem portray Indian English?
13. What does the speaker mean by "improve her prospect"?

14. How does the speaker end his speech?
15. What kind of person is Miss Pushpa according to the speaker?
16. What does the speaker remember about his stay in Surat?
17. How does the speaker create humour through his digression?
18. Explain the significance of the phrase “**Just now only I will do it.**”
19. What does the speaker mean by “external sweetness” and “internal sweetness”?
20. How does Nissim Ezekiel use satire in *Goodbye Party for Miss Pushpa T.S.*?

2. Pilgrimage – Shiv K. Kumar

About Shiv K. Kumar is a well-known Indian English poet, novelist, and playwright who played an important role in shaping modern Indian English literature. Born in Lahore in 1921, he later moved to India after Partition and became a respected academic and literary figure. He completed his higher education in Cambridge and was influenced by Western literary critics like F.R. Leavis. Shiv K. Kumar's poetry often reflects deep philosophical thoughts, spiritual questioning, and the complex emotions of modern life. His style combines Indian themes with modern techniques, making his work unique and thought-provoking.

About poem: One of his important poems, "Pilgrimage", is a symbolic and reflective piece that talks about the journey of life in the form of a spiritual pilgrimage. In the poem, the speaker shares his experience of going on various pilgrimages in search of truth or divine satisfaction. However, after completing the journey, he feels a sense of disappointment, as the expected spiritual transformation does not happen. The poem shows the contrast between outer religious practices and inner emptiness. It questions whether blindly following rituals without true self-understanding has any real value. Through this poem, Kumar suggests that the real pilgrimage is not just about visiting holy places, but about understanding one's own self and life. The tone of the poem is serious and thoughtful, and the language is simple yet powerful. "Pilgrimage" reflects the reality of many people's spiritual journeys, where the destination may not give the answers they were hoping for, and the journey itself becomes the true lesson.

1. Theme of the Poem:

- The main theme is the spiritual journey of life.
- It explores the search for truth, meaning, and inner peace.
- The poem questions blind faith and superficial religious rituals.
- It shows disillusionment when the end of the journey doesn't bring expected spiritual rewards.
- Emphasises that the real pilgrimage is within the self, not just external visits to holy places.
- The poem talks about a difficult journey (pilgrimage) where the travelers face challenges like heat and lack of supplies.
- It explores the idea of forced equality among the group, suggesting that despite differences, everyone suffers similarly.
- The poem questions blind faith and religious belief, suggesting that the gods may have tricked the people into following the journey without real purpose.
- It also reflects on human endurance, suffering, and doubt during spiritual or physical quests.

2. Tone and Mood:

- The tone is reflective, serious, and slightly ironic.
- It shows the speaker's disappointment and confusion after completing many pilgrimages.
- The mood is contemplative and philosophical.
- The tone is reflective, critical, and somewhat ironic.
- There is a feeling of unease and discomfort mixed with moments of humor or sarcasm.

3. Style and Language:

- Written in free verse – no rhyme scheme or fixed meter.
- Simple and clear language, yet full of symbolism and imagery.
- Uses conversational tone, making the poem feel personal and honest.

4. Imagery and Symbols:

- "Sweat of the soul" – symbolizes emotional and spiritual effort.
- "Circuit of pilgrimages" – represents repeated religious journeys.

- The journey itself becomes a metaphor for life and self-discovery.
- Sun's threats and dwindling supplies symbolize hardship and scarcity.
- The group is compared to a Persian mosaic, suggesting a colorful but complicated mix of people forced together.
- The trees, which "would have given us a guard of honour," symbolize nature's welcome, but the leader "defiled them with blasphemies," indicating disrespect or negativity.
- Marching crabwise (sideways) symbolizes an unusual or indirect approach to reaching the goal.

5. Message / Moral:

- True spiritual growth comes from introspection and inner change, not from outer rituals.
- The poet warns against the mechanical practice of religion without understanding or transformation.
- The journey is more important than the destination in the quest for truth.
- The poem warns against blindly following traditions or beliefs without questioning.
- It suggests that such journeys may be more about endurance and suffering than true spiritual growth.
- The narrator's caution shows the importance of thinking independently rather than accepting everything as truth.

6. Relevance:

- The poem is relevant to modern readers who may be spiritually confused or searching for meaning in a fast-changing world.
- It connects Indian cultural traditions with modern existential concerns.

7. Literary Devices:

- Imagery: vivid description of the sun, trees, and journey.
- Irony: The "enforced equalities" and the "trap" of belief suggest a critique of religion and pilgrimage.
- Metaphor: The pilgrimage itself symbolizes any difficult spiritual or life journey.

Not all of us spoke the same language—
some cowered under the sun's threats
and the dwindling supplies,
others felt amused
at the enforced equalities.
The bystanders took us for a Persian
mosaic of some insidious design.

Sometimes the urge to feign
was paramount. I pretended ataxia
to lag behind and visualize
more sharply the road's last, devious curve.

The trees on either side
would have given us a guard of honour
had our leader not defiled them
with blasphemies.

Then suddenly someone announced
that the easiest way to hit
the destination was to
march crabwise.

We were out to span the sky's amplitude—
this journey was merely to stimulate the blood.
The women mumbled, 'Rest would be haven—
indeed.'
I was the only one to caution
that the gods had trapped us
into belief.

Objective Type Questions (MCQs)

1. Who is the poet of "*Pilgrimage*"?

- A) Nissim Ezekiel
- B) Shiv K. Kumar
- C) A. K. Ramanujan
- D) Jayanta Mahapatra

Answer: B) Shiv K. Kumar

2. What does the poem primarily describe?

- A) A religious ceremony
- B) A journey or pilgrimage
- C) A war
- D) A festival

Answer: B) A journey or pilgrimage

3. Why did some members of the group cower?

- A) Because of rain
- B) Because of the sun's threats and dwindling supplies
- C) Because of wild animals
- D) Because they were lost

Answer: B) Because of the sun's threats and dwindling supplies

4. What did the bystanders compare the travellers to?

- A) A colourful painting
- B) A Persian mosaic
- C) A flock of birds
- D) A group of soldiers

Answer: B) A Persian mosaic

5. What did the speaker pretend to have?

- A) Amnesia
- B) Ataxia
- C) Fever
- D) Blindness

Answer: B) Ataxia

6. Why did the speaker pretend to have ataxia?

- A) To stop the journey
- B) To escape from the group
- C) To lag behind and observe the road more clearly
- D) To seek medical help

Answer: C) To lag behind and observe the road more clearly

7. What would the trees have given the travellers?

- A) Shelter
- B) A guard of honour
- C) Fruit

- D) Directions

Answer: B) A guard of honour

8. Who defiled the trees with blasphemies?

- A) The speaker
- B) The women
- C) The leader
- D) The bystanders

Answer: C) The leader

9. What unusual way of walking was suggested to reach the destination?

- A) Walking backwards
- B) Marching crabwise
- C) Running
- D) Walking in circles

Answer: B) Marching crabwise

10. What was the purpose of the journey according to the speaker?

- A) To find treasure
- B) To stimulate the blood
- C) To escape danger
- D) To meet the gods

Answer: B) To stimulate the blood

11. What did the women believe would be a haven?

- A) Food
- B) Water
- C) Rest
- D) The destination

Answer: C) Rest

12. What did the speaker caution the others about?

- A) The dangerous road
- B) The leader
- C) The gods' trap into belief
- D) The dwindling supplies

Answer: C) The gods' trap into belief

13. The phrase “span the sky's amplitude” suggests:

- A) Limiting one's ambitions
- B) Seeking vast or limitless possibilities
- C) Reaching a physical mountain
- D) Flying in an aircraft

Answer: B) Seeking vast or limitless possibilities

14. The word “ataxia” refers to:

- A) A disorder affecting coordination and balance

- B) A type of fever
- C) A religious practice
- D) A form of meditation

Answer: A) A disorder affecting coordination and balance

15. The word “**blasphemies**” means:

- A) Prayers
- B) Songs
- C) Irreverent or disrespectful expressions concerning the sacred
- D) Greetings

Answer: C) Irreverent or disrespectful expressions concerning the sacred

1. Short Answer Questions – *Pilgrimage* by Shiv K. Kumar

1. Why did some of the travellers cower under the sun's threats?
2. Why were some members of the group amused by the “enforced equalities”?
3. What did the bystanders think of the travellers?
4. Why does the poet compare the travellers to a “Persian mosaic”?
5. Why did the speaker pretend to suffer from ataxia?
6. What does the speaker mean by “the road's last, devious curve”?
7. What kind of “guard of honour” would the trees have given the travellers?
8. Why did the leader defile the trees with “blasphemies”?
9. What does “march crabwise” mean in the context of the poem?
10. What was the purpose of the journey according to the speaker?
11. Why did the women want to rest?
12. What does the phrase “span the sky's amplitude” suggest?
13. What does the speaker mean by saying that the journey was “merely to stimulate the blood”?
14. What warning did the speaker give about the gods?
15. What does the poem suggest about the different attitudes of the travellers towards the journey?
16. Explain the significance of the title “**Pilgrimage.**”
17. How does the poem present the idea of faith and belief?
18. What does the poem reveal about the speaker's attitude towards the journey?
19. Explain the significance of the phrase “**the gods had trapped us into belief.**”
20. How does Shiv K. Kumar use irony in the poem *Pilgrimage*?

Broad Questions

1. Explain how the poem "Pilgrimage" shows disappointment during the journey.
2. How does the poem criticize blind faith and rituals?
3. Write about the use of pictures and symbols in the poem.
4. Describe the tone and mood of the poem and how they affect its meaning.
5. How does the poem show the journey as both physical and spiritual?
6. Discuss how Shiv K. Kumar uses the journey in "Pilgrimage" as a metaphor for life's struggles and spiritual quest.
7. Analyze the role of skepticism and doubt in the poem. How does the narrator's attitude differ from the other pilgrims?
8. Explain how the poet uses imagery and symbolism to show the difficulties and futility of the pilgrimage.
9. How does the poem question traditional religious beliefs and practices?
10. Describe the different reactions of the pilgrims to the hardships they face during the journey.
11. In what ways does the poem "Pilgrimage" reflect the post-colonial Indian experience?
12. Explore the significance of the "march crabwise" and how it relates to the overall message of the poem.
13. How is the theme of unity and diversity portrayed in the poem?
14. Examine the poet's critique of leadership and authority as shown in the poem.
15. Write an essay on the symbolic importance of the physical and spiritual aspects of pilgrimage in the poem.

3.The Ghaghra in Spate – Keki N. Daruwalla

About Poet: Keki N. Daruwalla was born in 1937 in Lahore, which is now in Pakistan. After India's independence, he moved to India. He is a well-known Indian poet and writer who writes mostly in English. Daruwalla served in the Indian Police Service and also worked with the Intelligence Bureau, experiences which influenced his writing. He is famous for his poems about nature, human struggles, violence, and social issues.

Daruwalla's poetry is known for strong imagery and deep emotions, mixing personal and political themes. His work has been praised for its direct and powerful style. In 1984, he won the Sahitya Akademi Award, India's prestigious literary honor, for his poetry collection titled "Poems". Over the years, he has published many poetry books and short stories. He has also been a teacher and literary critic, contributing greatly to Indian English literature.

Daruwalla is an important figure in Indian poetry. His writings reflect both the beauty and harsh realities of life, and he remains respected for his contribution to literature.

About Poem:

The poem "The Ghaghra in Spate" by Keki N. Daruwalla describes the Ghaghra River during flood season. It shows how the river changes its course every year, causing destruction to nearby villages. The poem highlights the power of nature and the struggles of the people who live near the river. Despite the damage caused by the floods, the villagers quietly accept their fate and show resilience.

The three stages of the Ghaghra River as shown in the poem, related to the flood cycle:

1. Before the flood:

The river appears calm and quiet, almost like a "grey smudge" or a peaceful stretch of water, blending softly with the land.

2. During the flood:

The river becomes powerful and dangerous, flooding the villages, carrying away homes and animals. It is described as a "red weal" and causing destruction and fear.

3. After the flood:

When the flood recedes, the river turns “bitchy,” sucking away the land and damaging the banks. The fields hold trapped fish, and the land slowly sinks, showing the lasting damage caused by the flood.

1. Theme:

- The poem describes the power and unpredictability of nature, especially the floods of the Ghaghra River.
- It shows the suffering and difficulties faced by villagers whose homes and lives are affected by the flood.
- It explores the quiet acceptance and strength of people in the face of natural disasters.
- The poem reflects the relationship between humans and nature, showing both its beauty and its destructive force.
- It also highlights the cycle of destruction and survival in rural India.

2. Narrator’s Perspective:

- The narrator carefully observes the river and the lives of the villagers.
- There is admiration for the natural beauty of the river but also a realistic understanding of its dangers.
- The narrator shows sympathy for the villagers but accepts that nature’s power cannot be controlled.

3. Tone:

- The tone is serious and somber, showing the harsh reality of floods.
- It is calm and accepting, reflecting how people endure the disaster quietly.
- At times, the tone becomes vivid and descriptive, painting strong pictures of the river’s changing moods.

4. Imagery and Symbols:

- The poem uses strong visual images like “grey smudge,” “overstewed coffee,” and “red weal” to describe the river.
- Scenes of flooded villages, floating animals, and stranded people create a vivid picture of disaster and struggle.
- The river is personified as a living being with moods and actions, controlling the lives of the people.

- The floodwaters symbolize the uncontrollable force of nature and its impact on human life.

5. Literary Devices:

- Personification: The river “turns over in her sleep” and “steers her course,” giving it human qualities.
- Metaphor: The river is compared to “overstewed coffee” and a “red weal,” showing its changing moods.
- Alliteration: Repetition of sounds like “slush-stampede” adds rhythm and emphasis.
- Contrast: The calm beauty of the river is contrasted with the violent destruction caused by the floods.
- Symbolism: The river represents nature’s power and the struggles of the people living alongside it.

6. Message:

- The poem highlights the unpredictable and powerful nature of floods.
- It shows the suffering but quiet strength of rural people facing natural disasters.
- The poem suggests that humans must accept and respect nature’s forces, even when they bring hardship.
- It reflects the close and sometimes difficult relationship between humans and their environment.

And every year
the Ghaghra changes course
turning over and over in her sleep.

In the afternoon she is a grey smudge
exploring a grey canvas.
When dusk reaches her
through an overhang of cloud
she is overstewed coffee.
At night she is a red weal
across the spine of the land.

Driving at dusk you wouldn't know
there's a flood 'on ',
the landscape is so superbly equipoised-
rice-shoots pricking through
a stretch of water and light
spiked shadows
inverted trees
kingfishers, gulls.
As twilight thins
the road is a black stretch
running between the stars.

And suddenly at night
the north comes to the village
riding on river-back.
Twenty minutes of a nightmare spin
and fear turns phantasmal
as half a street goes
churning in the river-belly.
If only voices could light lamps!
If only limbs could turn to rafted bamboo!

And through the village
the Ghaghra steers her course;
thatch and dung-cakes turn to river-scum,
a buffalo floats over to the rooftop
where the men are stranded.
Three days of hunger, and her udders
turn red-rimmed and swollen
with milk-extortion.

Children have spirit enough in them
to cheer the rescue boats;
the men are still-life subjects

oozing wet looks.
They don't rave or curse
for they know the river's slang, her argot.
No one sends up prayers to a wasted sky,
for prayers are parabolic
they will come down with a flop anyway.
Instead there's a slush-stampede
outside the booth
where they are doling out salt and grain.

Ten miles to her flank
peasants go fishing in rice fields
and women in chauffeur-driven cars
go looking for driftwood.
But it's when she recedes
that the Ghaghra turns bitchy
sucking with animal-heat,
cross-eddies diving like frogmen
and sawing away the waterfront
in a paranoid frenzy.
She flees from the scene of her own havoc
thrashing with pain.
Behind her the land sinks
houses sag on to their knees
in a farewell obeisance.
And miles to the flank, the paddy fields
will hoard the fish
till the mud enters into
a conspiracy with the sun
and strangles them.

Objective type questions

1. Who is the poet of *The Ghaghra in Spate*?
 - A) Shiv K. Kumar

- B) Keki N. Daruwalla
- C) Nissim Ezekiel
- D) Jayanta Mahapatra

Answer: B) Keki N. Daruwalla

2. What does the Ghaghra do every year?

- A) Dries up
- B) Changes course
- C) Freezes
- D) Disappears

Answer: B) Changes course

3. How is the Ghaghra described in the afternoon?

- A) A silver ribbon
- B) A grey smudge
- C) A black snake
- D) A blue line

Answer: B) A grey smudge

4. What does the river resemble at dusk?

- A) Red wine
- B) Stewed tea
- C) Overstewed coffee
- D) Black ink

Answer: C) Overstewed coffee

5. What does the river look like at night?

- A) A red weal
- B) A golden thread
- C) A white cloud
- D) A dark shadow

Answer: A) A red weal

6. What natural disaster is described in the poem?

- A) Earthquake
- B) Cyclone
- C) Flood
- D) Drought

Answer: C) Flood

7. What crops are mentioned in the flooded landscape?

- A) Wheat
- B) Rice
- C) Cotton
- D) Sugarcane

Answer: B) Rice

8. Which birds are mentioned in the poem?

- A) Eagles and sparrows
- B) Crows and pigeons
- C) Kingfishers and gulls
- D) Parrots and peacocks

Answer: C) Kingfishers and gulls

9. What happens to half a street during the flood?

- A) It catches fire
- B) It sinks into the river
- C) It becomes a road
- D) It remains untouched

Answer: B) It sinks into the river

10. What does the poet wish could become a raft?

- A) Houses
- B) Limbs
- C) Trees
- D) Boats

Answer: B) Limbs

11. Where does the buffalo float?

- A) Across the rice field
- B) Towards the rescue boats
- C) Over to a rooftop
- D) Into the village square

Answer: C) Over to a rooftop

12. How long do the villagers suffer from hunger?

- A) One day
- B) Two days
- C) Three days
- D) Seven days

Answer: C) Three days

13. What happens to the buffalo's udders after three days of hunger?

- A) They become dry
- B) They become red-rimmed and swollen
- C) They disappear
- D) They become cold

Answer: B) They become red-rimmed and swollen

14. Who cheers the rescue boats?

- A) The women
- B) The men
- C) The children

- D) The fishermen

Answer: C) The children

15. What are the men compared to?

- A) Soldiers
- B) Still-life subjects
- C) Fishermen
- D) Statues of gods

Answer: B) Still-life subjects

16. Why do the villagers not rave or curse?

- A) They are unaware of the flood
- B) They know the river's "slang" and "argot"
- C) They have already escaped
- D) They are asleep

Answer: B) They know the river's "slang" and "argot"

17. Why does no one send up prayers?

- A) They do not believe in God
- B) They are too tired
- C) They think prayers will come down uselessly
- D) They are celebrating

Answer: C) They think prayers will come down uselessly

18. What is being distributed at the booth?

- A) Clothes and blankets
- B) Salt and grain
- C) Milk and water
- D) Medicine and food

Answer: B) Salt and grain

19. What do peasants do in the flooded rice fields?

- A) Swim
- B) Fish
- C) Work
- D) Build houses

Answer: B) Fish

20. What do women in chauffeur-driven cars look for?

- A) Food
- B) Lost cattle
- C) Driftwood
- D) Fishermen

Answer: C) Driftwood

21. When does the Ghaghra become particularly destructive?

- A) When it first arrives

- B) When it recedes
- C) At noon
- D) Before the monsoon

Answer: B) When it recedes

22. What does the river do to the waterfront?

- A) Beautifies it
- B) Builds it up
- C) Saws it away
- D) Covers it with flowers

Answer: C) Saws it away

23. What happens to the houses after the flood?

- A) They become stronger
- B) They are rebuilt immediately
- C) They sag onto their knees
- D) They float away completely

Answer: C) They sag onto their knees

24. What will the paddy fields hoard?

- A) Grain
- B) Water
- C) Fish
- D) Driftwood

Answer: C) Fish

25. What finally enters into a “conspiracy” with the sun?

- A) The river
- B) The mud
- C) The paddy
- D) The clouds

Answer: B) The mud

1. What does the poem “The Ghaghra in Spate” describe?
2. How does the river behave in the afternoon?
3. What image does the poet use to describe the river at dusk?
4. What happens to the village during the flood?
5. How do the villagers react to the flood?
6. What unusual sight is mentioned floating during the flood?
7. What does the poet say about prayers during the flood?
8. How long do the men remain hungry during the flood?
9. How do children behave when rescue boats arrive?

10. How is the river described at night?
11. What happens to the river after the flood recedes?
12. What do peasants do ten miles from the river during the flood?
13. What are women in cars searching for during the flood?
14. How does the land react after the river recedes?
15. What happens to houses during and after the flood?
16. How are the men described during the flood?
17. What phrase describes the sound of the flood?
18. How do the paddy fields change after the flood?
19. How are the women's breasts described in the poem?
20. What tone does the poem carry?
21. Which literary device is used when the river is said to "turn over in her sleep"?
22. What is the effect of comparing the river to "overstewed coffee"?
23. What does the poem suggest about human power over nature?
24. How do the villagers' reactions reflect their character?
25. What is the main message of the poem?

Short notes :

1. Write a short note on the Ghaghra river's behaviour before the flood.
2. Describe the appearance of the Ghaghra river in the afternoon.
3. Explain the significance of the river being compared to overstewed coffee.
4. What happens to the village during the flood?
5. How do the villagers respond to the flooding?
6. Discuss the symbolism of the buffalo floating on rooftops.
7. What does the poem say about the effectiveness of prayers during the flood?
8. Describe the state of the men during the flood.
9. How do children react to the arrival of rescue boats?
10. Write a note on the river's appearance at night.
11. What changes occur in the river's behaviour after the flood recedes?
12. How do peasants make use of the flooded rice fields?
13. What role do the women in chauffeur-driven cars play during the flood?
14. Explain how the land is affected after the floodwaters retreat.
15. Describe the condition of houses after the flood.
16. What does the phrase "slush-stampede" signify in the poem?
17. How does the poet depict the suffering of women during the flood?

18. Discuss the tone of the poem.
19. Explain the use of personification in the poem.
20. How does the poet use metaphor to describe the river?
21. What message does the poem convey about human control over nature?
22. How do the villagers show resilience during the flood?
23. Write a short note on the imagery used in the poem.
24. How does the poem portray the relationship between humans and nature?
25. Summarise the main theme of the poem.

On Killing A Tree - Poem by Gieve Patel

About Poet: Gieve Patel is an Indian poet, playwright, and painter born in 1940. He is known for his socially conscious and environmentally aware writings. Patel's poetry often reflects his concern for nature, society, and human emotions, blending vivid imagery with strong messages. He is considered an important voice in contemporary Indian English literature, and his works frequently explore the relationship between humans and the natural world.

About poem: The poem "On Killing a Tree" by Gieve Patel is a powerful and striking reflection on the resilience and strength of trees and nature. In the poem, Patel describes how difficult it is to kill a tree because it is deeply rooted in the earth and sustained by life forces beyond the surface. Unlike cutting grass, destroying a tree requires more than just chopping the branches; the roots must be torn out and the tree's life force must be destroyed. The poem highlights human violence against nature and warns about the consequences of harming the environment. It carries a serious tone and uses vivid imagery and symbolism to show the enduring spirit of trees and nature's resistance to destruction. The poem urges respect for nature and reminds readers of the deep connections between humans and the natural world.

Themes:

1. The poem talks about how humans harm nature in a violent way, especially trees, showing our careless attitude towards the environment.
2. It shows the strong and lasting power of trees, explaining that they cannot be easily killed because their roots go deep into the earth.

3. The poem tells us that trees are not just wood and leaves, but living beings connected deeply with life underground.
4. It gives a warning that destroying nature will have serious consequences and we should be careful and respectful towards it.

Tone:

The tone of the poem is serious and thoughtful. It shows anger against how humans destroy nature, but also respect for the strength of trees.

Literary Devices:

- The poem uses imagery to create strong pictures in our mind, like cutting the tree and pulling out its roots.
- Symbolism is used where the tree stands for nature and life itself.
- The tree is given human qualities, which is called personification (like when the poem says the tree's "life" has to be destroyed).
- There is alliteration too, with repeated sounds to give the poem a strong effect, for example, "bleeding bark" or "wounds open."

Structure and Style:

The poem is written in free verse, meaning there is no fixed rhyme or rhythm. This simple style helps the message come out clearly, like explaining step by step how a tree is killed.

Imagery:

The poem shows the hard work it takes to kill a tree — cutting the branches, tearing the bark, pulling out roots hidden deep in the soil.

Message:

The poem tells us that nature is powerful and alive, and it takes much more than just cutting to destroy it. It asks us to respect trees and nature because harming them badly will affect all life.

It takes much time to kill a tree,
Not a simple jab of the knife
Will do it. It has grown Slowly consuming the earth,
Rising out of it, feeding
Upon its crust, absorbing
Years of sunlight, air, water,

And out of its leperous hide
Sprouting leaves.
So hack and chop
But this alone wont do it.
Not so much pain will do it.
The bleeding bark will heal
And from close to the ground
Will rise curled green twigs,
Miniature boughs
Which if unchecked will expand again
To former size.
No,
The root is to be pulled out -
Out of the anchoring earth;
It is to be roped, tied,
And pulled out - snapped out
Or pulled out entirely,
Out from the earth-cave,
And the strength of the tree exposed,
The source, white and wet,
The most sensitive, hidden
For years inside the earth.
Then the matter
Of scorching and choking
In sun and air,
Browning, hardening,
Twisting, withering,
And then it is done.

Objective Questions

1. Who is the poet of "On Killing a Tree"?
 - a) Rabindranath Tagore
 - b) Gieve Patel
 - c) A.K. Ramanujan
 - d) Kamala Das

Answer: b) Gieve Patel

2. What is the central theme of the poem?

- a) Love and nature
- b) The difficulty of killing a tree
- c) The beauty of trees
- d) Growth of plants

Answer: b) The difficulty of killing a tree

3. What is the first step mentioned in the poem to kill a tree?

- a) Uproot it entirely
- b) Cut the bark and cut the roots
- c) Burn the leaves
- d) Water it less

Answer: b) Cut the bark and cut the roots

4. According to the poem, what is NOT enough to kill a tree?

- a) Cutting the leaves
- b) Cutting the bark
- c) Cutting the roots
- d) Uprooting the tree

Answer: a) Cutting the leaves

5. The poet says the tree's death is not immediate but:

- a) Instant
- b) Slow and painful
- c) Silent and painless
- d) Unnoticed

Answer: b) Slow and painful

6. What part of the tree holds the "living tissue" that helps it survive?

- a) Leaves
- b) Roots
- c) Bark
- d) Stem

Answer: c) Bark

7. The poem compares the tree's survival to:

- a) Human struggle
- b) Animal life
- c) Water flow
- d) Rock erosion

Answer: a) Human struggle

8. What is essential to kill a tree as per the poem?

- a) Only cutting the leaves
- b) Uprooting the roots and cutting the bark
- c) Burning the tree
- d) Pouring poison

Answer: b) Uprooting the roots and cutting the bark

9. The poet emphasizes the tree's ability to:

- a) Grow fruits quickly
- b) Regenerate even after being cut
- c) Provide shade only
- d) Live without roots

Answer: b) Regenerate even after being cut

10. What does the poet say is necessary to ensure the tree dies?

- a) Ignore it
- b) Cut it during winter
- c) Destroy the roots and bark completely
- d) Cover it with soil

Answer: c) Destroy the roots and bark completely

11. What literary device is prominently used in the line "It takes much time to kill a tree"?

- a) Metaphor
- b) Simile
- c) Personification

d) Hyperbole

Answer: d) Hyperbole

12. The tone of the poem can best be described as:

a) Joyful and celebratory

b) Angry and aggressive

c) Reflective and serious

d) Humorous and light-hearted

Answer: c) Reflective and serious

13. The poem suggests that cutting the tree superficially:

a) Will kill it instantly

b) Will only injure it temporarily

c) Has no effect

d) Makes it grow faster

Answer: b) Will only injure it temporarily

14. Which of the following is a metaphor used in the poem?

a) "Like a patient's slow dying"

b) "The leaves flutter in the wind"

c) "The bark is rough"

d) "The roots are underground"

Answer: a) "Like a patient's slow dying"

15. What does the poet imply about humans and trees?

a) Humans respect trees

b) Trees survive easily without humans

c) Humans harm trees carelessly

d) Humans depend on trees only for shade

Answer: c) Humans harm trees carelessly

16. What does the poem say about the tree's "skin"?

a) It is soft and fragile

b) It protects the tree like skin on a human

c) It has no role in survival

d) It is colorful and bright

Answer: b) It protects the tree like skin on a human

17. The phrase “to kill a tree you must damage the bark” is an example of:

a) An imperative statement

b) A question

c) An exclamation

d) A metaphor

Answer: a) An imperative statement

18. How does the poet describe the roots?

a) Weak and shallow

b) The source of life and strength

c) Unimportant

d) Always visible

Answer: b) The source of life and strength

19. What is the significance of the poem’s title, “On Killing a Tree”?

a) It suggests the ease of killing a tree

b) It highlights the complexity and brutality involved

c) It praises the beauty of trees

d) It talks about planting trees

Answer: b) It highlights the complexity and brutality involved

20. What message does the poem convey about nature?

a) Nature is fragile and easily destroyed

b) Nature fights back and is resilient

c) Nature does not matter

d) Nature is indifferent

Answer: b) Nature fights back and is resilient

21. What does the poet say about the tree’s “innards”?

a) They are easy to destroy

b) They hold the tree’s life and strength

c) They are not important

d) They grow outside the tree

Answer: b) They hold the tree's life and strength

22. What does the poem imply about the relationship between humans and trees?

- a) Humans and trees coexist peacefully
- b) Humans often destroy trees without understanding their resilience
- c) Trees depend on humans to survive
- d) Humans protect trees carefully

Answer: b) Humans often destroy trees without understanding their resilience

23. Why does the poet say that the tree cannot be killed by a single blow?

- a) Because it grows very fast
- b) Because its roots and bark must be destroyed first
- c) Because it lives underwater
- d) Because it is protected by animals

Answer: b) Because its roots and bark must be destroyed first

24. Which part of the tree does the poet emphasize as difficult to destroy?

- a) Leaves
- b) Bark and roots
- c) Flowers
- d) Fruits

Answer: b) Bark and roots

25. What is the poet's attitude towards cutting the tree?

- a) Casual and indifferent
- b) Thoughtful and cautionary
- c) Joyful and encouraging
- d) Ignorant and careless

Answer: b) Thoughtful and cautionary

Short Note Questions

1. Who is the poet of *On Killing a Tree*?
2. What is the main theme of the poem?
3. Why does the poet say cutting the leaves is not enough to kill a tree?
4. What must be done to kill a tree according to the poem?

5. How does the poet describe the tree's bark?
6. What role do the roots play in the survival of a tree?
7. What is the significance of the phrase "the living tissue under the bark"?
8. How does the poem describe the process of killing a tree?
9. Why does the poet compare killing a tree to hurting a human being?
10. What emotions or tone does the poem convey?
11. How does the poet illustrate the resilience of the tree?
12. What imagery is used to describe the roots in the poem?
13. What is the meaning of the line "It takes much time to kill a tree"?
14. How is the tree personified in the poem?
15. What does the poem suggest about human interaction with nature?
16. What message does the poet convey about the consequences of violence towards trees?
17. Why does the poet emphasize cutting the bark in addition to cutting the roots?
18. How is the idea of patience important in the poem?
19. How does the poet describe the inner strength of the tree?
20. What is the significance of the title *On Killing a Tree*?
21. How does the poem reflect the ecological importance of trees?
22. What does the poem say about the immediate effect of cutting a tree?
23. How does the poem contrast the appearance and the internal structure of the tree?
24. What metaphor does the poet use to describe the tree's slow death?
25. What lesson does the poem teach about destruction and survival in nature?

Short Stories

1. The Lost Child (Mulk Raj Anand)
2. The Doctor's Word (R.K. Narayan)
3. The Banyan Tree (Ruskin Bond)

1. The Lost Child – Mulk Raj Anand

About Mulk Raj Anand

Mulk Raj Anand was one of the most famous writers in Indian English literature. He was born on December 12, 1905, in Peshawar, which is now in Pakistan.

Anand is known for writing about the lives of poor and oppressed people in India. He was a pioneer of Indian English fiction and used his stories to highlight social issues like poverty, caste discrimination, and injustice. His writing style is simple, direct, and full of sympathy for common people.

Anand's famous works include novels like *Untouchable*, *Coolie*, and *Two Leaves and a Bud*. He was also a good short story writer, and *The Lost Child* is one of his popular short stories. In this story, Anand shows how a child experiences the excitement and fear of getting lost in a busy fair, reflecting the innocence and emotions of childhood.

Mulk Raj Anand believed that literature should serve a social purpose and help improve society. He was influenced by both Indian culture and Western writers like Maxim Gorky.

He passed away in 2004 but remains an important figure in Indian literature.

About the Story: The Lost Child

The Lost Child is a short story written by Mulk Raj Anand. It tells the story of a young boy who goes to a village fair with his parents. The fair is full of exciting things like toys, sweets, balloons, and games. The child is very happy and fascinated by everything he sees.

While enjoying the fair, the boy suddenly realizes that he is lost and cannot find his parents. He feels scared and cries loudly, calling for his mother and father. Many

kind people try to help him, but he is only comforted when he finally finds his parents again.

The story shows the feelings of a child — the joy of the fair, the fear of being lost, and the relief when reunited with family. It also teaches us how important parents are in a child's life.

Key Themes:

1. **Childhood Innocence:** The story beautifully shows a child's innocent and simple desires, like wanting toys, sweets, and balloons.
2. **Fear and Loneliness:** It explores the fear and helplessness a child feels when separated from parents in a crowded place.
3. **Importance of Family:** The child's ultimate wish is to be with his parents, showing how much love and security family provides.
4. **Compassion of Strangers:** The story also highlights kindness shown by strangers who try to help the lost child.

Moral of the Story:

The main moral of The Lost Child is that no material thing like toys or sweets can replace the love and security of parents. Even when surrounded by fun and excitement, a child feels safe only when with family. It teaches us to value our parents and family above all else.

Multiple Choice Questions (MCQs):

1. The story "**The Lost Child**" is written by:
 - A) R.K. Narayan
 - B) Khushwant Singh
 - C) **Mulk Raj Anand**
 - D) Ruskin Bond

Answer: C) Mulk Raj Anand
2. Where was the child going with his parents?
 - A) To a school
 - B) To a fair
 - C) To a temple

- D) To a market

Answer: B) To a fair

3. What season is suggested at the beginning of the story?

- A) Winter
- B) Monsoon
- C) Spring
- D) Autumn

Answer: C) Spring

4. What did the child see on the way to the fair?

- A) Beautiful flowers and butterflies
- B) Snow-covered mountains
- C) Ships and boats
- D) A railway station

Answer: A) Beautiful flowers and butterflies

5. What did the child want from his parents first?

- A) A toy
- B) A balloon
- C) A garland
- D) A horse

Answer: A) A toy

6. Why did the child hesitate to ask for the toy?

- A) He did not like toys.
- B) He knew his parents would refuse.
- C) He had no money.
- D) He was afraid of the shopkeeper.

Answer: B) He knew his parents would refuse.

7. What kind of toy attracted the child?

- A) A wooden horse
- B) A toy snake
- C) A toy soldier
- D) A doll

Answer: A) A wooden horse

8. What did the child see at the flowering mustard field?

- A) Bees and butterflies
- B) Birds and rabbits
- C) Horses and cows
- D) Fish and frogs

Answer: A) Bees and butterflies

9. What did the child want from the sweetmeat seller?

- A) Jalebi

- B) Burfi
- C) Gulab jamun
- D) Ladoo

Answer: B) Burfi

10. Why did the child not insist on getting the sweets?

- A) He was not hungry.
- B) He disliked sweets.
- C) He knew his parents would not buy them.
- D) The sweets were expensive.

Answer: C) He knew his parents would not buy them.

11. What did the child want from the flower seller?

- A) A rose
- B) A garland
- C) A lotus
- D) Jasmine oil

Answer: B) A garland

12. What did the child want from the balloon seller?

- A) A red balloon
- B) A bunch of balloons
- C) A blue balloon
- D) A balloon animal

Answer: B) A bunch of balloons

13. Why did the child avoid asking for balloons?

- A) He was frightened of balloons.
- B) He thought his parents would call him greedy.
- C) He had already bought one.
- D) The balloons had burst.

Answer: B) He thought his parents would call him greedy.

14. What attraction did the child see at the fair?

- A) A circus
- B) A roundabout
- C) A cinema
- D) A puppet theatre

Answer: B) A roundabout

15. What did the child want to do on the roundabout?

- A) Watch others ride it
- B) Ride on it
- C) Operate it
- D) Stop it

Answer: B) Ride on it

16. What happened when the child turned to ask his parents for the roundabout ride?

- A) They refused.
- B) They were buying sweets.
- C) He could not find them.
- D) They had gone home.

Answer: C) He could not find them.

17. What did the child realize suddenly?

- A) He had lost his money.
- B) He had lost his parents.
- C) The fair was closing.
- D) It was getting dark.

Answer: B) He had lost his parents.

18. What was the child's reaction after realizing he was lost?

- A) He became happy.
- B) He began to cry.
- C) He went to the roundabout.
- D) He bought sweets.

Answer: B) He began to cry.

19. Who picked up the lost child?

- A) A policeman
- B) A shopkeeper
- C) A kind-hearted man
- D) A balloon seller

Answer: C) A kind-hearted man

20. Where did the man find the child?

- A) Near the temple
- B) Near the roundabout
- C) At the sweetmeat shop
- D) Near the flower seller

Answer: B) Near the roundabout

21. What did the man offer the child first?

- A) A toy
- B) A balloon
- C) Sweets
- D) Flowers

Answer: C) Sweets

22. What did the child say when offered sweets?

- A) "I want burfi."
- B) "I want my father and mother."

- C) "Give me jalebi."
- D) "I want a toy."

Answer: B) "I want my father and mother."

23. What did the man offer the child after sweets?

- A) A garland
- B) A balloon
- C) A ride
- D) A toy

Answer: B) A balloon

24. Did the child accept the balloon?

- A) Yes
- B) No
- C) He asked for two balloons.
- D) He asked his parents first.

Answer: B) No

25. Why did the child refuse all the attractions offered by the man?

- A) He was tired.
- B) He was angry.
- C) He wanted only his parents.
- D) He wanted to go home alone.

Answer: C) He wanted only his parents.

Broad questions

1. Why did the child lag behind his parents at the fair?
2. What fascinated the child on the way to the fair?
3. How did the child react when he was separated from his parents?
4. What role did the stranger play in the story?
5. What is the central idea of the story?
6. Write a character sketch of the lost child.
7. Describe the fair as seen through the eyes of the child.
8. How does the story show the bond of love between parents and children?
9. "The child forgets his desires when he loses his parents." Discuss.
10. Explain the theme of parental protection and security in the story.
11. What attractions in the fair fascinated the child the most?
12. How did the child react after he was separated from his parents?
13. What is the central theme of the story "The Lost Child"?
14. What did the child want to buy at the toy shop?
15. Why did the child lag behind his parents?

16. How did the child behave after being lost?
17. What do we learn about parental love from this story?
18. Describe the role of the stranger who found the child.
19. What was the significance of the snake-charmer in the story?
20. How did the fair reflect the culture of rural India?
21. Why did the child refuse everything offered by the stranger?
22. What does the story reveal about children's psychology?
23. Explain how the author uses contrast between the child's desires before and after being lost.
24. How is the theme of material desires versus emotional security portrayed?
25. Describe the atmosphere of the fair and how it adds to the story.
26. Discuss the role of the stranger who finds the child.
27. What is the universal message of The Lost Child?
28. How were the parents guiding the child at the fair?

2. The Doctor's Word – R.K. Narayan

About R. K. Narayan: R. K. Narayan, whose full name was **Rasipuram Krishnaswami Iyer Narayanaswami**, was one of the most prominent Indian writers in English literature. He was born on October 10, 1906, in Madras (now Chennai), India, and spent most of his life in Mysore, a city that greatly influenced his writing. Narayan is best known for creating the fictional South Indian town of Malgudi, which became the setting for most of his stories and novels. His works are known for their simplicity, gentle humor, and deep insight into the everyday lives of ordinary people in India. His writing style was straightforward and elegant, often focusing on middle-class characters and exploring themes such as tradition versus modernity, human relationships, and the cultural shifts occurring in India during and after British rule.

Narayan began his literary career with his first novel, "Swami and Friends," published in 1935 with the support of British writer Graham Greene. The novel introduced readers to Malgudi, a town that would go on to become an iconic

symbol in Indian literature. Over the years, Narayan wrote several acclaimed novels such as "The Bachelor of Arts," "The English Teacher," "The Financial Expert," and "The Guide." "The Guide" won the Sahitya Akademi Award in 1958 and was later adapted into a successful Hindi film. Another one of his most beloved works is "Malgudi Days," a collection of short stories that was also turned into a popular television series in the 1980s, further cementing his legacy in Indian popular culture.

In his lifetime, Narayan received numerous awards and honors, including the Padma Bhushan in 1964 and the Padma Vibhushan in 2000. He was also nominated to the Rajya Sabha, the upper house of India's Parliament, in 1989. His autobiography, "My Days," published in 1974, provides insight into his personal life, including the tragic loss of his wife, which deeply affected him and inspired some of his more emotional writing. Narayan's contribution to Indian English literature is immense. Alongside contemporaries like Mulk Raj Anand and Raja Rao, he is regarded as a pioneer who brought Indian stories to a global audience through the English language. He passed away on May 13, 2001, but his stories continue to resonate with readers across generations for their warmth, wit, and timeless portrayal of Indian life.

About the Story: "The Doctor's Word"

"The Doctor's Word" is a short story by R. K. Narayan that reflects his signature style — simple yet deeply insightful, with a focus on human relationships and moral dilemmas. It is set in the fictional town of Malgudi, like many of his other stories.

Summary of the Story

The story revolves around Dr. Raman, a well-known and honest doctor in Malgudi, who is known for speaking the harsh truth to his patients. He does not believe in giving false hope and always tells his patients exactly what their condition is, even if they are near death.

One day, his close friend Gopal falls seriously ill and is brought to him for treatment. Dr. Raman examines Gopal and realizes that he is in critical condition

and might not survive. However, Gopal asks him directly, “Is it serious?” and pleads to know the truth.

This situation puts Dr. Raman in a moral conflict. If he tells Gopal the truth — that his condition is likely fatal — it might cause shock and hasten his death. On the other hand, if he lies, he will go against his own principles of honesty.

Eventually, Dr. Raman chooses to lie for the first time in his professional life. He tells Gopal that there is no danger and that he will recover soon. Strangely enough, Gopal does survive, and the story ends with Dr. Raman relieved but surprised at the irony of the situation.

Themes in “The Doctor’s Word”

1. Moral Dilemma and Ethics

The central theme is the ethical conflict between professional honesty and personal emotion. Dr. Raman is torn between his habit of truth-telling and his emotional connection to his friend.

2. Power of Words

The story explores how a doctor's words can influence life and death, not just through medicine but also through the mental state of the patient. Dr. Raman’s lie, intended to comfort, possibly saves his friend.

3. Friendship and Compassion

The bond between Dr. Raman and Gopal is strong. Even though Dr. Raman is a man of science and logic, his compassion for his friend overrides his rigid principles.

4. Irony

The ending is ironic. Dr. Raman lies to save his friend — a rare decision for him — and the lie turns out to be life-saving. This adds depth to the theme of unpredictability in life and medicine.

5. Human Psychology

The story subtly touches on how the mind can influence the body, suggesting that belief, hope, or reassurance can play a role in healing.

Characters

Dr. Raman – A skilled, honest, and emotionally detached doctor who believes in telling the truth at all costs, until faced with a personal conflict.

Gopal – Dr. Raman's close friend and patient, who trusts the doctor completely and depends on his words for hope.

Setting

The story is set in Malgudi, a fictional South Indian town. The setting reflects a typical Indian atmosphere — close-knit communities, personal relationships, and a blend of traditional values with modern professions like medicine.

Style and Language

R. K. Narayan uses simple, clear language and gentle irony. The narration is straightforward, but it carries emotional depth and moral weight. The story is short but packed with tension and meaning.

Moral / Message of the Story

The story suggests that compassion is sometimes more important than rigid honesty, especially in matters of life and death. It highlights the power of hope and the importance of considering the emotional well-being of others. It also shows that even people who value truth above all may be forced to reconsider when faced with love, loyalty, and human vulnerability.

Multiple Choice Questions (MCQs):

1. **“The Doctor’s Word”** is written by:
 - A) Mulk Raj Anand
 - B) R. K. Narayan
 - C) Ruskin Bond
 - D) Khushwant Singh

Answer: B) R. K. Narayan

2. What was the name of the doctor in the story?

- A) Dr. Raman
- B) Dr. Gopal
- C) Dr. Raghavan
- D) Dr. Krishna

Answer: A) Dr. Raman

3. Dr. Raman was known for his:

- A) Wealth
- B) Strictness
- C) Truthfulness and professional honesty
- D) Political influence

Answer: C) Truthfulness and professional honesty

4. How long had Dr. Raman known Gopal?

- A) Since childhood
- B) Since college
- C) For ten years
- D) For only a few months

Answer: A) Since childhood

5. What was Gopal's profession?

- A) Teacher
- B) Lawyer
- C) Businessman
- D) Farmer

Answer: C) Businessman

6. What happened to Gopal?

- A) He had an accident
- B) He became seriously ill
- C) He lost his business
- D) He was attacked

Answer: B) He became seriously ill

7. Where was Gopal taken for treatment?

- A) A government hospital
- B) Dr. Raman's clinic
- C) His friend's house
- D) A nursing home

Answer: B) Dr. Raman's clinic

8. What did Dr. Raman initially think about Gopal's condition?

- A) It was completely harmless.
- B) It was very serious.
- C) It was imaginary.

- D) It was caused by food poisoning.

Answer: B) It was very serious.

9. What did Dr. Raman discover after examining Gopal?

- A) Gopal had a broken bone.
- B) Gopal was suffering from a serious heart condition.
- C) Gopal had malaria.
- D) Gopal had a minor infection.

Answer: B) Gopal was suffering from a serious heart condition.

10. What did Dr. Raman tell Gopal about his condition?

- A) He gave him a completely accurate but frightening diagnosis.
- B) He told him he would recover immediately.
- C) He refused to examine him.
- D) He sent him abroad.

Answer: B) He told him he would recover immediately.

11. Why did Dr. Raman decide to tell Gopal that he would recover?

- A) He wanted to earn more money.
- B) He wanted to give Gopal hope.
- C) He did not understand the illness.
- D) He wanted to deceive Gopal permanently.

Answer: B) He wanted to give Gopal hope.

12. What did Dr. Raman usually believe about a doctor's duty?

- A) A doctor should always tell the patient the truth.
- B) A doctor should avoid patients.
- C) A doctor should never operate.
- D) A doctor should always give false hope.

Answer: A) A doctor should always tell the patient the truth.

13. What was unusual about Dr. Raman's statement to Gopal?

- A) He refused to treat him.
- B) He gave him false reassurance despite his serious condition.
- C) He asked him to leave.
- D) He blamed him for his illness.

Answer: B) He gave him false reassurance despite his serious condition.

14. What did Dr. Raman's words give Gopal?

- A) Fear
- B) Anger
- C) Hope and confidence
- D) Confusion

Answer: C) Hope and confidence

15. What was Gopal's response to Dr. Raman's assurance?

- A) He became more frightened.
- B) He became cheerful and confident.
- C) He refused treatment.
- D) He left immediately.

Answer: B) He became cheerful and confident.

16. What did Dr. Raman have to do because of Gopal's condition?

- A) Perform an operation
- B) Send him home without treatment
- C) Leave the town
- D) Call the police

Answer: A) Perform an operation

17. Why was the operation particularly difficult for Dr. Raman?

- A) He had never performed an operation before.
- B) Gopal's life was in great danger.
- C) He disliked Gopal.
- D) There was no hospital.

Answer: B) Gopal's life was in great danger.

18. What did Dr. Raman feel before the operation?

- A) Complete confidence
- B) Anxiety and uncertainty
- C) Anger
- D) Indifference

Answer: B) Anxiety and uncertainty

19. What was the result of the operation?

- A) Gopal died.

- B) Gopal survived.
- C) Gopal left the hospital.
- D) The operation was cancelled.

Answer: B) Gopal survived.

20. What role did Dr. Raman's words play in the story?

- A) They increased Gopal's fear.
- B) They gave Gopal hope and courage.
- C) They caused the illness.
- D) They prevented treatment.

Answer: B) They gave Gopal hope and courage.

21. What quality of Dr. Raman is most strongly highlighted?

- A) Greed
- B) Professional responsibility
- C) Laziness
- D) Jealousy

Answer: B) Professional responsibility

22. What does the title “**The Doctor's Word**” refer to?

- A) A doctor's written prescription
- B) The doctor's assurance that Gopal would recover
- C) A medical textbook
- D) A hospital rule

Answer: B) The doctor's assurance that Gopal would recover

Important One-Word/Very Short Answers

1. Who is the protagonist of the story?

Dr. Raman

2. Who is Dr. Raman's patient?

Gopal

3. What is Dr. Raman's profession?

Doctor

4. What is Gopal's relationship with Dr. Raman?

Childhood friend

5. What does Gopal need?

An operation

6. What does Dr. Raman give Gopal besides medical treatment?
Hope
7. What happens to Gopal at the end?
He survives
8. What is the central theme of the story?
The power of a doctor's words, hope, and professional responsibility.

Broad questions

1. Why did people in Malgudi respect Dr. Raman?
2. Why was Dr. Raman considered a blunt doctor?
3. What promise did Gopal's wife ask from Dr. Raman?
4. Why did Dr. Raman go against his principles in this story?
5. What moral lesson do we learn from the story?
6. Sketch the character of Dr. Raman.
7. Why is Dr. Raman's lie considered more valuable than the truth in this story?
8. Describe the conflict Dr. Raman faced when Gopal's wife asked him about her husband's health.
9. Justify the title The Doctor's Word.
10. What does this story teach us about truth, duty, and compassion?
11. Why was Dr. Raman respected in Malgudi?
12. How was Dr. Raman different from other doctors?
13. Why did Dr. Raman assure Gopal's wife that her husband would live?
14. Explain the conflict in Dr. Raman's mind when he had to speak to Gopal's wife.
15. What does the story teach us about truth and compassion?
16. What qualities made Dr. Raman unique as a doctor?
17. How did Gopal's wife react when Dr. Raman gave his word?
18. What change did Dr. Raman undergo in the story?
19. How does the story highlight the bond of friendship between Dr. Raman and Gopal?
20. Why did Dr. Raman's lie turn out to be a "life-giving truth"?
21. Discuss the ethical dilemma faced by Dr. Raman.
22. How is honesty portrayed in contrast with compassion in the story?
23. Write a character sketch of Gopal's wife.

- 24.Explain the importance of Dr. Raman’s reputation in Malgudi.
- 25.What lesson about humanity and duty does the story teach?
- 26.Why did Dr. Raman lie to Gopal’s wife?
- 27.What quality of Dr. Raman is highlighted in the story?
- 28.Explain how the title “The Doctor’s Word” is justified.

3. The Banyan Tree – Ruskin Bond

About Ruskin Bond : Ruskin Bond is one of the most loved and respected writers in Indian English literature. He was born on 19 May 1934 in Kasauli, Himachal Pradesh, to British parents. Even though he has British roots, he has spent most of his life in India and considers himself very much Indian at heart. He writes mainly in English but his stories deeply reflect Indian culture, nature, and simple village life.

Ruskin Bond spent his early childhood in different parts of India like Jamnagar, Dehradun, and Shimla. After his parents separated, he stayed with his father, who passed away when Bond was still very young. This loss deeply affected him and can be seen in the emotional depth of his writing. He later went to England for a short time but returned to India as he always felt more connected to Indian life and people.

He is best known for his short stories, novels, essays, poems, and children's books. Some of his most famous works include "The Room on the Roof", which was his first novel and won the John Llewellyn Rhys Prize, "The Blue Umbrella", "Rusty the Boy from the Hills", and "A Flight of Pigeons". His stories are known for their simplicity, emotional warmth, and deep connection with nature and small-town India. He often writes about the hills of Garhwal and Mussoorie, where he has lived for many years.

Ruskin Bond’s writing style is simple, clear, and heartfelt, which makes it easy for both children and adults to enjoy his stories. He often writes from personal experiences and uses nature, friendship, childhood, and nostalgia as main themes.

His stories teach us to appreciate the beauty in ordinary life and the importance of human values like kindness, honesty, and love.

Over the years, Ruskin Bond has received many awards, including the Sahitya Akademi Award, Padma Shri, and Padma Bhushan. Even today, he continues to write and remains active in the literary world. He lives in Landour, near Mussoorie, and is often seen interacting with readers, especially young fans.

Ruskin Bond is a true storyteller whose works have touched the hearts of millions. His stories are a gentle reminder of the joy found in everyday moments, the charm of childhood, and the timeless beauty of the Indian hills.

About Story: "The Banyan Tree" is a short story by Ruskin Bond, taken from his semi-autobiographical collection of stories based on his childhood experiences. The story beautifully captures the innocence of childhood, the wonders of nature, and the joys of quiet observation. It reflects Bond's deep love for nature and simple village life, written in his usual clear and heartfelt style.

Summary of the Story

The story is narrated by a young boy (based on Ruskin Bond himself), who lives with his grandparents in a house with a large garden. The central focus of the story is the old banyan tree in the garden, which becomes a world of adventure and discovery for the boy. Since he is often alone — as his grandfather considers him too young to play with the other children — he spends most of his time reading, observing, and daydreaming under the banyan tree.

One of the most memorable events in the story is when the boy witnesses a fierce fight between a cobra and a mongoose from the safety of the tree. He watches the battle with excitement and curiosity, describing every move carefully. In the end, the mongoose kills the cobra, and the event leaves a deep impression on the boy. Later, the boy also sees a pair of squirrels and a koel bird building their nests in the tree. He begins to feel a bond with the animals and birds living in and around the banyan tree. The tree becomes a symbol of friendship, discovery, and peaceful coexistence with nature. It is not just a tree for him — it is a world full of stories.

Themes in "The Banyan Tree"

1. Connection with Nature

The story reflects how deeply a child can connect with nature when given time and space to explore. The banyan tree represents a safe haven and a place of learning.

2. Childhood and Curiosity

The story captures the innocence and curiosity of childhood. The boy observes the world around him with wonder, asking no big questions, just enjoying what he sees.

3. Loneliness and Imagination

Though the boy is often alone, he never feels bored. His imagination, books, and the life around the banyan tree keep him company.

4. Violence and Survival in Nature

The fight between the cobra and the mongoose shows the harsh realities of nature — where survival often comes through strength and instinct. Yet it is described not with horror, but with a sense of respect for the natural world.

5. Observation and Learning

The story teaches that one doesn't need school or formal education all the time — nature itself can be the best teacher if we watch closely and patiently.

Style and Language

Ruskin Bond uses simple, descriptive, and poetic language. He brings the scenes to life with vivid imagery — like the movements of the mongoose and cobra, the rustling leaves, and the still afternoon air. His style makes the reader feel like they are sitting right there on the banyan tree, watching the world unfold.

Moral / Message

The story encourages readers to appreciate the beauty of nature, to observe life with curiosity, and to understand that learning can happen anywhere, not just in classrooms. It also shows how a child's world, even when quiet or lonely, can be full of magic and adventure.

1. Who is the narrator of “The Banyan Tree”?

- a. A child
- b. A traveler
- c. A farmer
- d. Ruskin Bond himself

Answer: a. A child

2. The banyan tree stood in the narrator's:

- a. School ground
- b. Grandfather's house
- c. Garden
- d. Park

Answer: b. Grandfather's house

3. Which two creatures had a fierce fight under the banyan tree?

- a. A cat and a dog
- b. A snake and a mongoose
- c. A tiger and a goat
- d. A monkey and a parrot

Answer: b. A snake and a mongoose

4. The banyan tree stood in the house of the narrator's

- a. Father
- b. Grandfather
- c. Uncle
- d. Neighbor

Answer: b. Grandfather

5. The narrator spent his time in the banyan tree by

- a. Flying kites
- b. Reading books
- c. Writing stories
- d. Watching birds

Answer: b. Reading books

6. The main fight described in the story was between a mongoose and a

- a. Cobra
- b. Rat
- c. Cat
- d. Snake

Answer: a. Cobra

7. Which bird also joined the fight?

- a. Crow
- b. Pigeon
- c. Sparrow
- d. Eagle

Answer: a. Crow

“The Old Banyan Tree” is written by:

- o A) R. K. Narayan
- o B) Mulk Raj Anand
- o C) Ruskin Bond
- o D) Keki N. Daruwalla

Answer: C) Ruskin Bond

Where did the old banyan tree stand?

- o A) In a forest
- o B) Near the author's house
- o C) Beside a river
- o D) In a school garden

Answer: B) Near the author's house

What kind of tree was the banyan?

- o A) Young and small
- o B) Old and enormous
- o C) Short and weak
- o D) Newly planted

Answer: B) Old and enormous

What did the banyan tree provide during summer?

- o A) Fruits

- B) Shade
- C) Flowers
- D) Water

Answer: B) Shade

Which creatures are associated with the banyan tree?

- A) Snakes and squirrels
- B) Tigers and deer
- C) Elephants and monkeys
- D) Fish and frogs

Answer: A) Snakes and squirrels

What did the tree's branches provide for birds?

- A) Food
- B) Nesting places
- C) Water
- D) Protection from hunters only

Answer: B) Nesting places

What did the author often do under the banyan tree?

- A) Sleep
- B) Read and observe nature
- C) Play cricket
- D) Cook food

Answer: B) Read and observe nature

What does the banyan tree symbolize in the work?

- A) Fear and loneliness
- B) Strength, shelter and continuity
- C) War and destruction
- D) Wealth

Answer: B) Strength, shelter and continuity

The banyan tree is presented as:

- A) A threat to humans
- B) A living part of the natural world

- C) A useless tree
- D) A symbol of urban development

Answer: B) A living part of the natural world

What is the author's attitude towards the banyan tree?

- A) Fearful
- B) Indifferent
- C) Affectionate and admiring
- D) Hostile

Answer: C) Affectionate and admiring

11. The banyan tree stood in the house of the narrator's

- a. Father
- b. Grandfather
- c. Uncle
- d. Neighbor

Answer: b. Grandfather

12. The boy spent most of his time in the banyan tree by

- a. Playing games
- b. Reading books
- c. Sleeping
- d. Writing

Answer: b. Reading books

13. The fight under the banyan tree was between a mongoose and a

- a. Snake
- b. Cobra
- c. Rat
- d. Cat

Answer: b. Cobra

14. Which two birds took part in the fight?

- a. Crow and pigeon
- b. Crow and sparrow

- c. Sparrow and parrot
- d. Crow and eagle

Answer: a. Crow and pigeon (Mostly crow is mentioned; pigeon is sometimes seen in versions, but crow definitely)

15. The banyan tree was older than the boy's-----.

- a. Grandfather
- b. House
- c. School
- d. Garden

Answer: b. House

16. The boy often watched small creatures like ----- near the tree.

- a. Ants
- b. Butterflies
- c. Insects
- d. Birds

Answer: c. Insects (small creatures usually refer to insects)

17. The cobra in the story raised its hood like a -----.

- a. Fan
- b. Umbrella
- c. Shield
- d. Leaf

Answer: b. Umbrella

18. The fight between the cobra and mongoose ended with the death of the -----.

- a. Mongoose
- b. Cobra
- c. Crow
- d. Boy

Answer: b. Cobra

Short Answer Questions

1. Who wrote “The Old Banyan Tree”?
Ruskin Bond
2. What is the main subject of the work?
An old banyan tree
3. What does the tree provide to people?
Shade and shelter
4. What does the tree provide to birds and animals?
Food, shelter and a place to live
5. What does the banyan tree symbolize?
Strength, permanence and harmony with nature
6. What is the author's attitude towards nature?
He has deep affection and respect for nature.
7. What is the central theme?
The beauty of nature and the bond between humans and the natural world.

Broad questions

1. Why was the banyan tree special for the boy?
2. How did the narrator describe the banyan tree?
3. Describe the fight between the mongoose and the cobra.
4. What role did the crow and the myna play in the story?
5. What is the message of the story?
6. Describe the bond between the narrator and the banyan tree.
7. Narrate the mongoose and cobra fight as seen by the boy.
8. How is the banyan tree a symbol of companionship and wisdom in the story?
9. Discuss the story as an example of Ruskin Bond’s love for nature.
10. What lessons can humans learn from observing animals and birds, as shown in the story?
11. How did the narrator describe the banyan tree?
12. What happened during the fight between the cobra and the mongoose?
13. Why did the narrator call the banyan tree his “library”?
14. What role did the myna and the crow play in the story?
15. What message does the story convey about observing nature?
16. How did the narrator spend his time on the banyan tree?
17. Describe the fight between the mongoose and the cobra.
18. What lesson does the story “The Banyan Tree” teach us about nature?

19. What role did the banyan tree play in the boy's childhood?
20. How did the boy describe the cobra before the fight?
21. What did the mongoose do to defend itself against the cobra?
22. What did the myna do at the end of the fight?
23. Why does Ruskin Bond often choose nature as the background of his stories?
24. Explain how the story blends childhood innocence with the cruelty of nature.
25. Describe the role of birds in the mongoose–cobra fight.
26. How does the banyan tree serve as both a playground and a place of learning?
27. Discuss The Banyan Tree as a nature story with a moral.
28. How does the author show the balance of life and death in nature?